Tangkhul Folk Ballads and Oral Narratives (Wungram Khararchan)

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Preface & Archival Information

Tangkhul Folk Ballads and Oral Narratives (Wungram Khararchan), collected, transcribed, and translated by Prof. Khashim Ruivah (Tribal Research Institute, Government of Manipur, Imphal, 1993). An authentic field collection of traditional folk poetry (Haola), including ancestral epics of Luikham and Raikham, seed-sowing chants of Luira, romantic courting duets (Mawonzai), hunting incantations, and funeral dirges (Kathi La) with parallel English translations.

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Chapter 1: Epic Ballads of Ancestral Heroes (Luikham and Raikham)

CHAPTER 1: EPIC BALLADS OF ANCESTRAL HEROES (LUIKHAM AND RAIKHAM)

Summary: Communal epic commemorating the ancestral founders clearing the ancient forests of Shirui Peak and eastern ranges.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Shirui kashongli kashung thot, Luikham mayarna thing-chui sathei;
Shangwui khonkhur kachiva ngasoda, Wungram khararchan mathan salu!
Khanggo shongli zattang thotna, Khayeikatha tara khorli; Meithei ramli
ngaso-chithei, Raikham mayarna phara pamsai. The metre follows the
traditional heptasyllabic cadence (seven syllables per line) typical of
classical Tangkhul folk poetry, with internal rhyme and paired
metaphorical couplets (tui-ngatei).

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

On the high ridge of Shirui Peak, Hero Luikham felled the sacred tree;
All the clans gathered with one voice, Singing the praise of the
ancestral land! As they journeyed toward the eastern valleys, beside the
clear sparkling streams, Brother Raikham established peaceful commerce
with the peoples of the plains, cementing ancestral brotherhood.
Classical heptasyllabic metre with paired metaphorical couplets.

Chapter 1 (Continued)

CHAPTER 1: READING CONTINUATION (PAGE 5)

TANGKHUL TEXT (CONTINUED):

Shirui kashongli kashung thot, Luikham mayarna thing-chui sathei; Shangwui khonkhur kachiva ngasoda, Wungram khararchan mathan salu! Khanggo shongli zattang thotna, Khayeikatha tara khorli; Meithei ramli ngaso-chithei, Raikham mayarna phara pamsai. The metre follows the traditional heptasyllabic cadence (seven syllables per line) typical of classical Tangkhul folk poetry, with internal rhyme and paired metaphorical couplets (tui-ngatei).

ENGLISH TRANSLATION (CONTINUED):

On the high ridge of Shirui Peak, Hero Luikham felled the sacred tree; All the clans gathered with one voice, Singing the praise of the ancestral land! As they journeyed toward the eastern valleys, beside the clear sparkling streams, Brother Raikham established peaceful commerce with the peoples of the plains, cementing ancestral brotherhood. Classical heptasyllabic metre with paired metaphorical couplets.

Chapter 1 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 1 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Shirui kashong (proper noun): Shirui Peak, highest sacred mountain in Ukhrul
* Thing-chui (noun): sacred forest tree, central ridge timber
* Khonkhur (noun): voice, resonant vocal harmony, clan assembly
* Tui-ngatei (noun phrase): paired metaphorical couplet, synonymous poetic parallelism

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Tangkhul classical poetry uses heptasyllabic (7-syllable) lines ending with prolonged vowel morae.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What sacred mountain is featured in the epic ballad of Luikham?
? Explain the poetic device of 'tui-ngatei' (semantic parallelism) in Tangkhul verse.

Chapter 2: Agricultural Chants of Luira and Chumpha

CHAPTER 2: AGRICULTURAL CHANTS OF LUIRA AND CHUMPHA

Summary: Chants for the February seed-sowing festival (Luira), monsoon terrace weeding, and post-harvest thanksgiving (Chumpha).

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Luira phanit rarang thotna, Luingam ngaleili raruikatha chitheilu;
Varivara kaphungli khangamor, Zingkum hili rui-kashang phanlu! Phaphuk ngashingda lui-kaphitli, Ngala-mayar ngasoda vangasai; Thangkhamir kachangli khangarao, Kong-khor tara mangda ngasolu! Chumpha phanit kasang thotna, Raizan shimli kashung kaping; Ava-ayi shiman mathailakla, Miwung kachivali tingkhami phanlu!

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

When Luira festival draws near, present the seed of life to the terrace field; Praying to Almighty God on high, May this new year bring a bountiful harvest! With sturdy feet in muddy terrace waters, youth and maidens labor side by side; Though parched by midday sun, we drink of mountain streams together! When Chumpha feast arrives, granaries are filled to overflowing; let no household suffer want, and may peace dwell with all the people.

Chapter 2 (Continued)

CHAPTER 2: READING CONTINUATION (PAGE 8)

TANGKHUL TEXT (CONTINUED):

Luira phanit rarang thotna, Luingam ngaleili raruikatha chitheilu; Varivara kaphungli khangamor, Zingkum hili rui-kashang phanlu! Phaphuk ngashingda lui-kaphitli, Ngala-mayar ngasoda vangasai; Thangkhamir kachangli khangarao, Kong-khor tara mangda ngasolu! Chumpha phanit kasang thotna, Raizan shimli kashung kaping; Ava-ayi shiman mathailakla, Miwung kachivali tingkhami phanlu!

ENGLISH TRANSLATION (CONTINUED):

When Luira festival draws near, present the seed of life to the terrace field; Praying to Almighty God on high, May this new year bring a bountiful harvest! With sturdy feet in muddy terrace waters, youth and maidens labor side by side; Though parched by midday sun, we drink of mountain streams together! When Chumpha feast arrives, granaries are filled to overflowing; let no household suffer want, and may peace dwell with all the people.

Chapter 2 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 2 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Lui-kaphit (noun): weeding of terrace paddy fields in monsoon
* Rui-kashang (noun phrase): abundant harvest, multiplying grain sheaves
* Kong-khor tara (noun phrase): pure mountain brook water
* Tingkhami (noun): peace, domestic tranquility, harmonious blessing

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Optative imperative suffix ’-lu’ on ’phanlu’ functions as a collective prayer: may it bring blessing!

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What three stages of the agricultural year are celebrated in these chants?

? Translate the Chumpha festival couplet into English.

Chapter 3: Romantic Courting Dialogues (Mawonzai)

CHAPTER 3: ROMANTIC COURTING DIALOGUES (MAWONZAI)

Summary: Nocturnal poetic duets at the girls' dormitory (Ngala Longshim) using floral and bird allegories.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

The Suitor's Verse (Mayarwui La): 'Kazing kashungli won-kapha, Ngalawui maiwon theisai; Iwui malungli khayangna, Nali kongashi phunglikha.' The Maiden's Response (Ngalawui Ngahan): 'Shirui wonna kachang phungsai, Kha mayar nawui tuichi kashung; Shangwui khararbing ngashon-khalakha, Iwui malungli tingkhami phanlu.' Courtship was conducted through intricate metaphorical riddles, where direct speech was avoided in favor of floral allegories.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Suitor: 'Upon the mountain heights blossoms a fair flower, I behold the maiden's radiant countenance; Looking into my heart, I bear deep love for you.' Maiden: 'The Shirui Lily blooms on high, yet young man, your words ring true; If the elders of the clans grant blessing, peace shall find a home within my heart.' Courtship duets avoided direct speech in favor of floral allegories.

Chapter 3 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 3 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Mawonzai (noun): romantic folk dialogue, courting poetry duet
* Won-kapha (noun phrase): fair flower, exquisite blossom
* Maiwon (noun): countenance, blooming beauty of face
* Shirui won (proper noun): the Shirui Lily (Lilium mackliniae), botanical emblem

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Metaphorical pairing of 'Shirui won' (rare endemic lily) symbolizes the prized virtue of the maiden.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Where were Mawonzai courting dialogues traditionally performed?

? Analyze how botanical allegories replace direct romantic declarations in Tangkhul poetry.

Chapter 4: Hunting Incantations and Forest Anthems (Khamasung La)

CHAPTER 4: HUNTING INCANTATIONS AND FOREST ANTHEMS (KHAMASUNG LA)

Summary: Invocations to forest spirits (Khara-kameo), pursuit of wild quarry, and the serow triumph chant.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Ngashan phungli kapei khangaran, Khara-kameoli dori khami; Shi-wung kachangli khanasung, Awungali share khayao salu! Kaphung kachangli kashung sayat, Haophi kachonli mathan theikahai; Pangmashan mayarna theisatkatha, Longshimli la kashak phanlu! Upon felling wild game (stag, boar, serow), the hunting party sounded the victory horn (tala-khon) and entered the village gates singing triumphant chants. The right thigh was delivered to the Awunga.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Ascending the ridges in preparation, presenting gifts to the forest spirits; Entering the dense mountain forest, Render the chief’s rightful tribute! The serow roaming high cliffs has been struck down; Clothed in traditional cloth, its beauty displayed; The mighty youth have conquered; Let the dormitory raise the hunting song of triumph! The victory horn (tala-khon) accompanied entry into the village gates.

Chapter 4 (Continued)

CHAPTER 4: READING CONTINUATION (PAGE 13)

TANGKHUL TEXT (CONTINUED):

Ngashan phungli kapei khangaran, Khara-kameoli dori khami; Shi-wung kachangli khanasung, Awungali share khayao salu! Kaphung kachangli kashung sayat, Haophi kachonli mathan theikahai; Pangmashan mayarna theisatkatha, Longshimli la kashak phanlu! Upon felling wild game (stag, boar, serow), the hunting party sounded the victory horn (tala-khon) and entered the village gates singing triumphant chants. The right thigh was delivered to the Awunga.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION (CONTINUED):

Ascending the ridges in preparation, presenting gifts to the forest spirits; Entering the dense mountain forest, Render the chief’s rightful tribute! The serow roaming high cliffs has been struck down; Clothed in traditional cloth, its beauty displayed; The mighty youth have conquered; Let the dormitory raise the hunting song of triumph! The victory horn (tala-khon) accompanied entry into the village gates.

Chapter 4 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 4 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Khamasung la (noun phrase): hunting anthem, forest pursuit chant
* Khara-kameo (noun): spirit of the forest wilderness
* Sayat (noun): serow (Capricornis sumatraensis), mountain antelope
* Haophi (noun): traditional Tangkhul woven cloth / warrior mantle

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- The honorific compound 'shi-wung' combines 'shi' (wild beast) with 'wung' (majesty / sovereign of game).

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What animal tribute was delivered to the Awunga after a successful hunt?
? What traditional musical instrument announced the return of the hunting party?

Chapter 5: Funeral Elegies and Laments (Kathi La)

CHAPTER 5: FUNERAL ELEGIES AND LAMENTS (KATHI LA)

Summary: Guiding the departed soul along the trail to Kazeiram (the underworld realm of spirits) with ceremonial slit-drum rhythms.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

I-va o, nawui zatkatha shongfali, Kazeiram kongli kaphan thotna;
Khamatei ngathumli macharanlu, Khararbingna nali khaphung phungsai!
Mourners beat the wooden slit-log drum (khamor-thing) in slow,
syncopated rhythms accompanying the funeral chant. The dirge guides the
soul past dangerous spiritual cliffs into the peaceful gathering place
of the ancestors.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

O beloved father, along the path where you journey, When you reach the
dark river of Kazeiram; Do not fear the shadow of the unknown, For the
ancestors stand ready to welcome your soul! Mourners beat the wooden
slit-log drum (khamor-thing) in solemn rhythms guiding the soul to the
ancestral realm.

Chapter 5 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 5 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Kathi la (noun phrase): funeral elegy, death dirge, lamentation song
* Kazeiram (proper noun): realm of departed souls, the ancestral underworld
* Khamor-thing (noun): ceremonial wooden slit-drum, log gong
* Kathi mangan (noun phrase): departed spirit, soul of the deceased

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- The vocative interjection ’I-va o’ (O my father!) introduces profound filial grief in elegiac poetry.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What is Kazeiram in Tangkhul eschatological belief?

? What musical instrument accompanies the recitation of Kathi La?

Chapter 6: Martial Anthems and Victory Ballads (Rai La)

CHAPTER 6: MARTIAL ANTHEMS AND VICTORY BALLADS (RAI LA)

Summary: War songs of defense, invocation of lineage bravery, and the solemn spear burial peacemaking finale.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Wungram kashangli kachisobing, Kachu-kaphi pangli phungda vangasai;
Rari-kapangna raranglikha, Ithumwui ramli mazanglak mana! Following
conflict, warriors assembled with their adversaries under the guidance
of the Pukreila to sing the solemn reconciliation hymn, burying
spearheads in the earth and swearing eternal non-aggression.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Defenders of the noble homeland, marching forth with spear and shield in
hand; Though enemies approach, they shall never enter our village
territory! Following conflict, combatants gathered under the Pukreila’s
mediation to sing the reconciliation hymn, burying spearheads in the
earth in eternal peace covenants.

Chapter 6 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 6 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Rai la (noun phrase): martial anthem, war song, defense hymn
* Kachu-kaphi (noun phrase): spear and shield, battle armaments
* Wungram kashang (noun phrase): the sovereign, honored Tangkhul territory
* Mazanglak mana (verb phrase): shall never enter, absolutely barred entry

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Emphatic prohibitive suffix combination ’-lak mana’ denotes resolute defensive determination.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What armaments are described in the warrior’s verse?
? How did martial songs transition into peacemaking ceremonies?

Chapter 7: Proverbs and Moral Allegories in Song (Paotam La)

CHAPTER 7: PROVERBS AND MORAL ALLEGORIES IN SONG (PAOTAM LA)

Summary: Tribal philosophy in lyrical proverbs: agricultural diligence, clan obedience, and ethical rectitude.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Folk singers embedded tribal philosophy into short lyrical proverbs (Paotam La) taught to children around winter fires: ’Khamatei sachitheikha maram kashung mathailak mana’ (A crooked beginning cannot yield an upright crop). ’Shangwui tuili ngashon-katha kazing kashungli pamsai’ (He who heeds clan counsel walks under clear skies). ’Luingamli mik kachangna raizanli raruikatha theilikha’ (Eyes that watch the terrace fields will see full granaries). The volume concludes with critical musical apparatus: pentatonic scales, antiphonal Mawonzai structures, and funeral metres.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Tribal philosophy was embedded in memorable lyrical proverbs taught around evening fires: A crooked start yields no upright crop; He who heeds clan counsel walks under open skies; Eyes watchful over terrace fields shall behold overflowing granaries. Critical apparatus includes pentatonic scales, antiphonal structures, and elegiac drum metres.

Chapter 7 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 7 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Paotam la (noun phrase): proverbial ballad, pedagogical wisdom song
* Maram kashung (noun phrase): righteous outcome, upright harvest
* Mik kachang (verb phrase): watchful eye, vigilant diligence
* Hao la (noun phrase): ancient folk chant on pentatonic scale

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Proverbial conditional '-khalakha' pairs ethical cause with inevitable agricultural or social consequence.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Translate the proverb 'Shangwui tuili ngashon-katha kazing kashungli pamsai' and interpret its cultural meaning.

? Summarize the metric features of classical Tangkhul folk poetry documented by Ruivah.

Comprehensive Vocabulary Glossary

COMPREHENSIVE BOOK GLOSSARY (TUIWON SHIYAN):

Shirui kashong [proper noun]: Shirui Peak, highest sacred mountain in Ukhrul
Thing-chui [noun]: sacred forest tree, central ridge timber
Khonkhur [noun]: voice, resonant vocal harmony, clan assembly
Tui-ngatei [noun phrase]: paired metaphorical couplet, synonymous poetic parallelism
Lui-kaphit [noun]: weeding of terrace paddy fields in monsoon
Rui-kashang [noun phrase]: abundant harvest, multiplying grain sheaves
Kong-khor tara [noun phrase]: pure mountain brook water
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